

# Key Components in Product Management Success (and Failure)

## A Model of Product Managers' Job Performance and Job Satisfaction in the Turbulent 1990s and Beyond

*Van R. Wood and Sudhir Tandon*

### Introduction

A product manager is OK for picking a pretty package and playing footsie with the ad agency, but he's basically an ivory-tower MBA, corporate climber who wouldn't know a customer if one hit him over the head with a jumbo pack of Charmin toilet tissue (Urbanski, 1987, p. 42).

As alluded to in the above quote, product managers have lost some of their corporate luster. More to the point, in the eyes of many observers, today's highly volatile marketing environment, engendered by burgeoning new technologies, the rise of retail power, and fragmented consumer markets, has significantly decreased the relevance of traditional product management. Companies which once relied on "the system" to co-ordinate the many activities involved in developing and marketing consumer products now question its value. New systems, bearing

new executive titles (e.g. category manager, geographic manager, key accounts manager, regional market manager, even product management teams) now claim to be the most effective means of managing multi-product companies (Meserve, 1989; Schiller, 1992).

Notwithstanding these sentiments, most practitioners still agree that the traditional product management system is far from obsolete (most products, particularly new ones, still require a product manager to co-ordinate the functional labyrinth of complex companies, plan long-term strategies, and watch over profitability (see Crawford, 1991; Taylor, 1989). Nevertheless, a strong challenge has been issued to both managers and researchers to find and blend the elements for successful product management in the 1990s and beyond. Important questions beg consideration: What are the sources of success in contemporary product management? Are there key ingredients to product managers' productivity and job satisfaction? And, in light of the challenges product managers now face,

how do such ingredients fit together nomologically?

This article attempts to provide some initial answers to these and other questions. Drawing on boundary spanning theory, role dynamics theory and strategic contingency theory, this work offers a new conceptualization of the product manager's role and postulates a series of relationships to explain product managers' job performance and satisfaction. While acknowledging that successful product management may also be determined by a myriad of other variables (personal, environmental, and organizational), this article focusses on a specific set of behavioral activities, the behavioral consequences of such activities, and organizational characteristics that, together, perhaps most influence contemporary product managers' success and failure. We begin with a brief review of the product management system and job, highlighting the environmental changes that are challenging the value of traditional product management.

## **The Product Management System and Job: The Challenge of Change**

While it has been reported that the genesis of the product management system was long before the 1950s (Procter & Gamble utilized an early version of it in the 1930s), it was then that its common use came into being (Buell, 1975). During the 1950s and early 1960s, many consumer goods companies found themselves faced with opportunities theretofore not witnessed. It was a period marked by rapid economic growth, heightened consumer demand, and the rise of mass markets and mass media. Significant increases in consumer discretionary income drove competition and led to an explosion of new product and brand offerings. To cope with the inherent complexities of this new environment

better, the modern product management system emerged.

From its inception, product management represented an organizational response to mass marketing opportunities. It was a new approach to harmonizing the many business facets required to manage successfully companies with multiple products and brands aimed at large homogeneous markets. As initially developed (and still practiced in many companies), a single executive, namely the product or brand manager, was assigned responsibility for planning, coordinating, and integrating the activities of research and development, finance, accounting, production, distribution and marketing, with the ultimate objective being a pre-established level of profitability for a specific product or brand. Since product managers developed strategies for products and then spearheaded the necessary departmental coordination to implement those strategies, they often acquired significant influence within their organizations (Cosse and Swan, 1983; McDaniel and Gray, 1980).

Over the years, the product management system became enormously productive. It has been credited with much of the success of giant companies such as Kraft, General Foods, General Mills, Procter & Gamble, Pillsbury, Heinz, Quaker Oats, Campbell Soup, PepsiCo and Frito-Lay, along with many other smaller consumer goods producers representing food, drug, toiletry, clothing, appliance, tool and other industries. As the system prospered, product management became an increasingly accepted and largely unquestioned way of doing business. As late as 1986, product management was touted as the key to successful marketing (Randolph and Hamilton, 1986). However, during the last five or so years, many practitioners and academics have come to question the traditional role of product managers, if not the very system itself (Dewar and Schultz, 1989; Power 1992; Urbanski, 1987). There are

several reasons behind this questioning, all of which point to a specific fact – the marketplace today is very different from the one in which product management was born and flourished.

Perhaps the biggest agent of change in recent years has been technology. With the development and use of the Universal Product Code, retail scanner data, Direct Product Profit programs and store patronage recorders, the ability of product managers to influence retail stocking decisions using traditional data sources has waned considerably. Retailers are realizing that they have powerful data gathering and evaluation technologies that give them a local information edge. For example, scanner technologies can measure product performance almost instantly, and today, 80 percent of supermarkets and 50 percent of retailers use bar-code scanners (*Business Week*, 1993). As such, shelf space allocation can now be objectively based on information other than the six week-old Nielsen data or Arbitron's (now defunct) SAMI Services data that product managers typically used when explaining why consumers were buying their brands, and why their products should remain on retail shelves (Caminiti, 1990). The new technologies, more and more, now allow retailers to confirm what consumers want, and where and when they want it.

The traditional influence wielded by product managers, due to their massive promotion expenditures, has also waned. Most retailers now realize that being a distribution point for highly advertised national brands, or even their own brands, is not necessarily related to success in the marketplace. Today, many competing retailers carry the same brands and thus receive the same benefits from a given national or regional mass advertising campaign. And, thanks to the Robinson-Patman Act, most have access to the same promotion or discount deals offered by a given product manager. As such, for

many retailers, contemporary marketing success lies in differentiating themselves from other retailers. The key is to build store loyalty, rather than the brand loyalty traditionally demanded by product managers. Because of their growing power and independence, some observers predict that retailers will come more and more to dictate delivery terms, advertising format, and pricing and product quality levels to consumer goods producers, all of which have historically been controlled by product managers (Dewar and Schultz, 1989; Loden, 1992; Schiller, 1992).

Another force challenging the value of traditional product management is rising consumer sophistication. Driven primarily by comparative advertising, ingredient disclosure laws and unit pricing, consumers have become more knowledgeable and more demanding (Butaney and Wortzel, 1988; Byer and Cooke, 1985; Levy, 1987). They also have come to view themselves as independent individuals rather than a mass market. As a consequence, they have become less susceptible to mass advertising and less brand loyal to nationally advertised products (Maital, 1991). Similarly, recent evidence indicates that, in order to keep within their budgets, many consumers are relying more and more on retail store brands (*Opinion Research Inc.*, 1993). The question then arises: Do traditional product managers, trained to focus on products while seeking efficiencies through mass promotions, common packaging and standardized product features, all aimed at the widest possible audiences, possess the skills needed to succeed in today's sophisticated and fragmented markets? More to the point, what skills are needed to succeed if product managers and their companies are to remain successful and influential in the 1990s and beyond?

Again, while most students of product management still believe the traditional system is far from obsolete, many now agree that a refocusing of the system is necessary

(Crawford, 1991; Taylor, 1989). In general terms, successful product managers of the future, be they category managers, geographic managers, key account managers, or otherwise, will be required to understand and respond to the specific needs of powerful retailers and demanding consumers. More specifically, they will have to coordinate their organizations' activities more acutely around individual stores and highly targeted customers, rather than just products. The following model further explores these complex issues.

### **A Theoretical Model of Behavioral and Organizational Factors Underlying Product Managers' Job Performance and Satisfaction**

Figure 1 displays the proposed model, linking behavioral activities, organizational characteristics, behavioral consequences of such activities, and product managers' job-related outcomes. The model emphasizes the antecedents leading to performance and satisfaction of product managers, and provides a framework for the following review of the constructs and the linkages proposed. We begin with the primary, and perhaps most important, ingredient of product managers' jobs – boundary spanning.

#### ***Boundary Spanning***

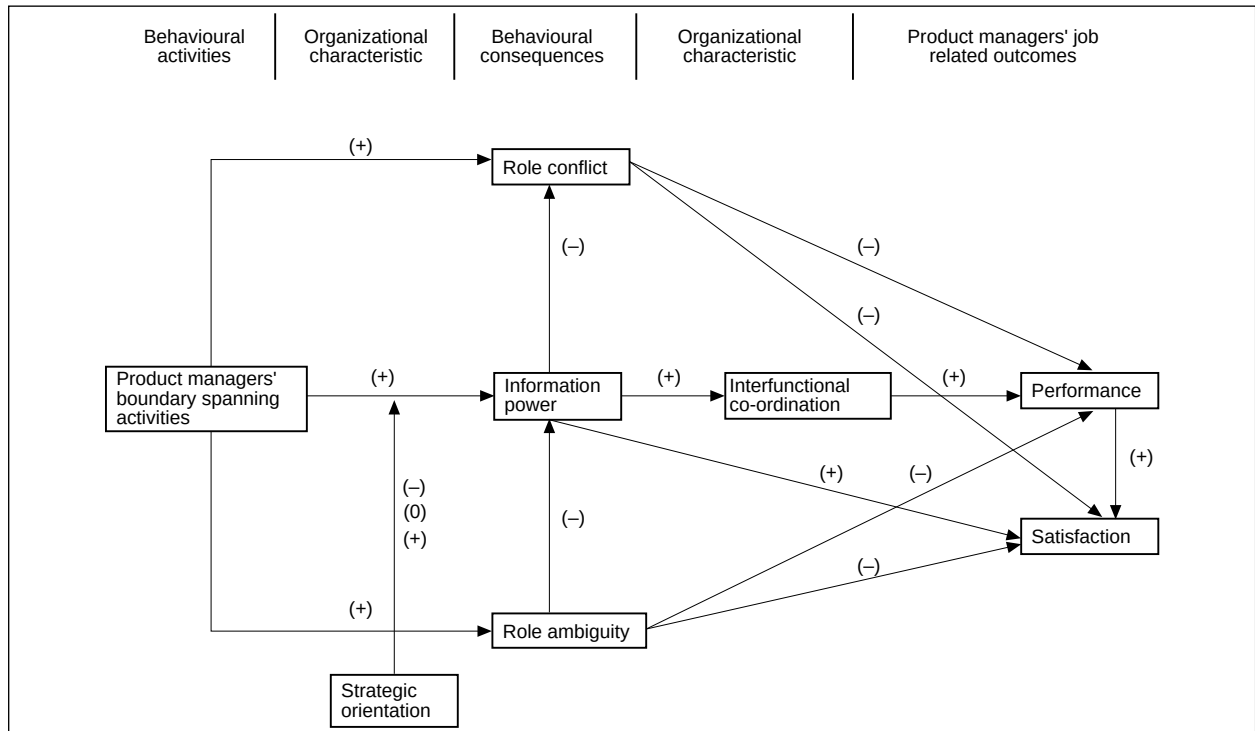
To understand fully the means by which product managers achieve high performance and high job satisfaction, an understanding of the boundary spanning concept and related boundary spanning activities is required. A substantial body of research indicates that boundary spanning is an important mechanism that links an organization to sources of information (Lyonski, 1985; Tushman and Scanlan, 1981). Within the context of product management, a common

theme is that effective boundary spanning is a two-part process, namely:

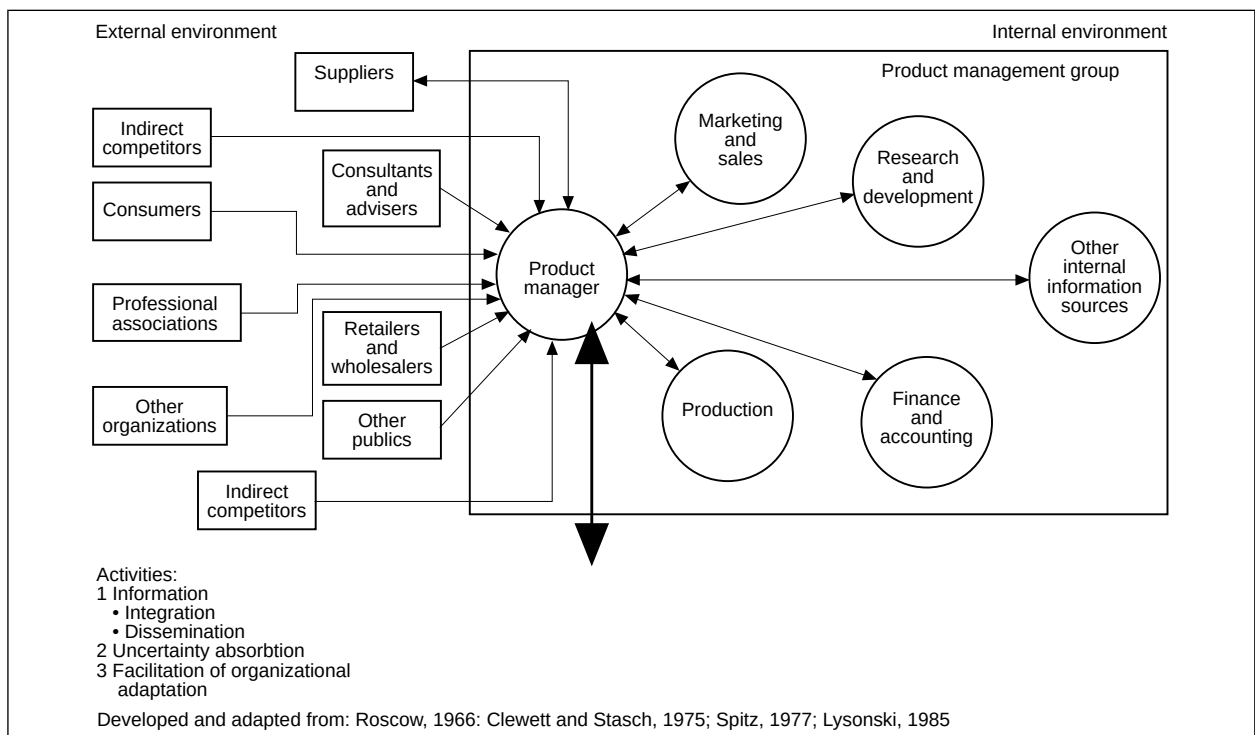
- (1) obtaining information from inside and outside the organization;
- (2) disseminating this information to all parties relevant to successful marketing of a product or brand. As shown in Figure 2, boundary spanning product managers interact with a myriad of departments and organizations in the routine performance of their duties in order to:
  - integrate and disseminate information;
  - absorb uncertainty;
  - facilitate their organization's adaptation to changing environments.

As they integrate information, product managers seek ideas from various sources, outside their organizations, and from functional departments within their organizations. Highly productive product managers often cultivate close relationships with contacts from both inside and outside their organizations. They disseminate information to both inside and outside constituencies using knowledge gained through reading relevant newspapers, magazines and journals; perusing government and market reports; closely monitoring competition; and compiling their own reports from such sources. Throughout this process, they are interacting with key individuals who play unique but vital roles in the success (or failure) of their products and brands. As with information integration, the ultimate objective of information dissemination is to facilitate the coordination of all relevant parties involved in successful marketing of products and brands (Lyonski, 1985).

In most situations, product managers serve a dual function in information exchange, acting as both filters and facilitators of the



**Figure 1.**  
**A Conceptual Model of the Dynamics Underlying Product Managers' Performance and Job Satisfaction**



**Figure 2.**  
**The Boundary Spanning Environment: Information Sources and Activities**

process. They filter information by engaging in “uncertainty absorption”; that is, they draw inferences from many sources of information and package them so that a parsimonious picture of the environment is revealed (Nonaka and Nicosia, 1979). This, in turn, prevents information overload (where too much information clouds rather than clarifies a situation), and facilitates the transmission of meaningful information to the appropriate decision maker.

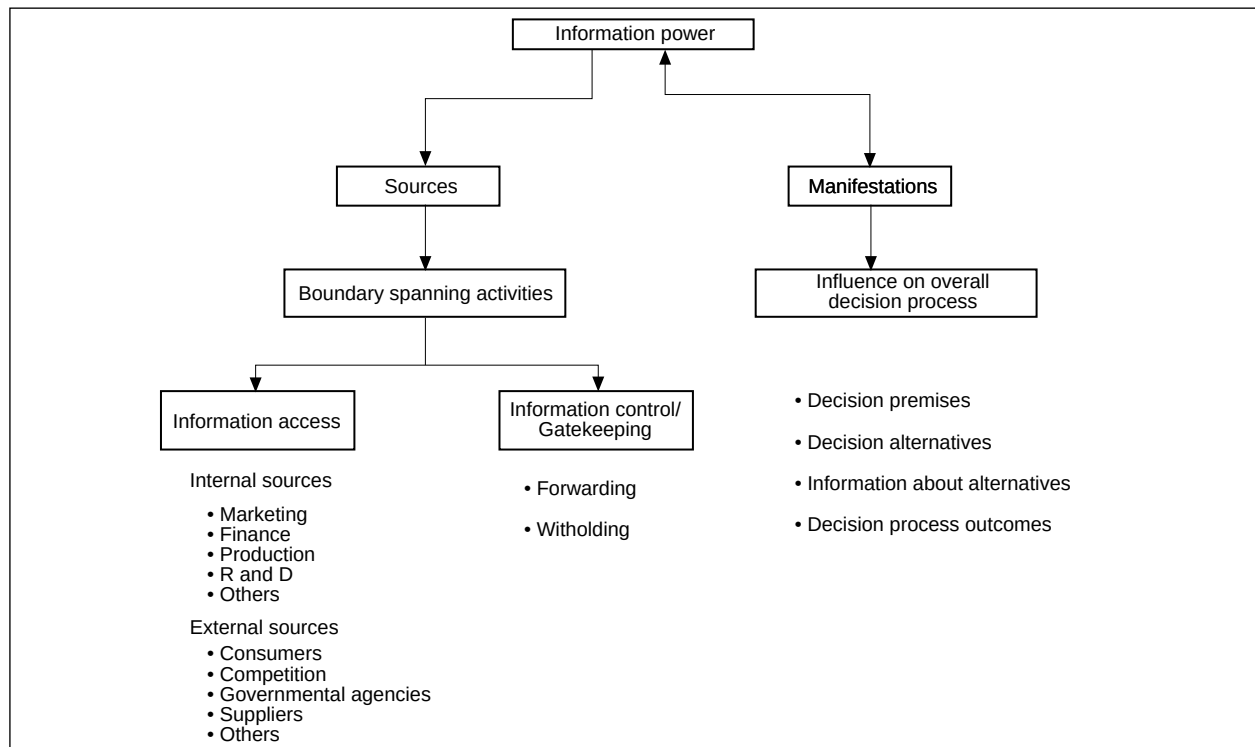
Leifer and Huber (1976) posited that the primary importance of boundary spanning lies with the need to have accurate information concerning environmental changes reach decision makers in a timely fashion. The ultimate objective is to enable organizations to adapt to any and all pertinent contingencies. In theory, the success of this “adaptation” process in product management depends heavily on a product manager’s ability to blend information gathered from his or her boundary spanning activities, both inside and outside the organization. Despite this theoretically compelling prescription for success, many contemporary product managers have spent a good deal, if not most, of their time and energy on internal boundary spanning activities. As suggested in this article’s opening quotation, many product managers are perceived to know internal product and package design people, along with internal promotion people, much better than they know relevant and important external people, particularly retailers and customers. To many observers, this is somewhat of a paradox because, as the external environment facing organizations becomes more turbulent, external boundary spanning activities (again see Figure 2) become even more critical to an organization’s ability to adapt, survive and prosper (Caminiti, 1990; Power, 1992). Before addressing this issue further, another association (boundary spanning activities and subsequent power) merits consideration.

### **Boundary Spanning Activities and Power**

Power has long been a central concept in the analysis of intraorganizational behaviors (Bacharach and Lawler, 1980; Crozier, 1964). In general, power is said to be derived from dependence, which is defined as a direct function of the importance of what one person (A) gets from another person (B). When A has something that B desires and no one else can offer it as A does, then A has power over B, because B is dependent on A.

All organizations depend on a continuous supply of resources in order to survive and thrive. Some resources (e.g. expertise, knowledge, information) tend to be more critical to an organization’s operations than others (e.g. clerical staff, office machines, office space). The more critical a resource, the more dependent an organization becomes on it. Cyert and March (1963), along with Hickson *et al.* (1971), were some of the first to argue that environmental information is perhaps the most critical resource to modern organizations. As such, those who, by virtue of their organizational position, have a gateway to and command over environmental information come to be depended on and, thus, tend to acquire power. Such is the case with boundary spanning product managers whose power is derived primarily as a result of their ability to gather, filter, integrate, control and disseminate information deemed crucial to their organizations’ success (Kohli, 1989).

Raven (1965), and more recently Kohli (1989), used the term “information power” to describe this phenomenon. As depicted in Figure 3, product managers’ information power is derived from the boundary spanning activities that give them access to and control over information. This power, in turn, is manifest through an influence over the overall decision processes and, ultimately, over the market(s) an organization selects to serve and the strategies with which it chooses to serve them. As alluded to by Piercy (1989), a two-way linkage between information power and



**Figure 3.**  
**The Sources and Manifestations of Information Power**

the manifestations of such power exists. That is, as information power gives product managers influence over decision processes, such influence ultimately enhances their information power[1].

By virtue of their position as boundary spanners at the perimeter of organizations, product managers are exposed to a large amount of information (some relevant and some not) which they filter and present to their organizations. As proposed graphically in Figure 1, these boundary spanning activities (and the related access to and control over valuable information) give them information power. However, as expressed earlier, the environment in which product managers now function has changed dramatically. The market, buffeted by new technologies, rising retail power and more discerning consumers, has evolved. No longer is an over-emphasis on internal boundary spanning (which often results in a product focus or even product

myopia) the recipe for success. Getting closer to the customer, doing more field work, and knowing retailers will have to become a bigger part of the equation in future product management systems. More specifically, if product managers are to acquire and maintain information power (which, as will be explained, is ultimately related to job performance and satisfaction), then outside boundary spanning that provides meaningful “market” information relevant to the co-ordination of functional efforts is required. Based on this reasoning, the following propositions are advanced:

*P1:* The greater the number of meaningful boundary spanning activities (both inside and outside the organization) undertaken by product managers, the greater their information power.

*P2:* Product managers’ information power is more dependent on (i.e. more highly

correlated with) their outside boundary spanning activities than their inside boundary spanning activities.

### ***Interfunctional Coordination***

As shown in Figure 1, information power, when positively associated with interfunctional coordination, can directly affect product managers' performance and satisfaction. As such, a look at interfunctional coordination and its association with information power is appropriate.

One important characteristic of most large organizations is the division of labor, or what is known as "task specialization". Thompson (1967), and later Pfeffer (1978) and Ruekert and Walker (1987a), noted that task specialization can have numerous positive effects on organizations, including enhancing economies of expertise (i.e. allowing individuals to focus on their specialties), circumventing the limits of bounded rationality (i.e. the inability of individuals to be knowledgeable about many areas), and overcoming the limits of information processing capacity (i.e. the inability of individuals to take many factors into consideration simultaneously).

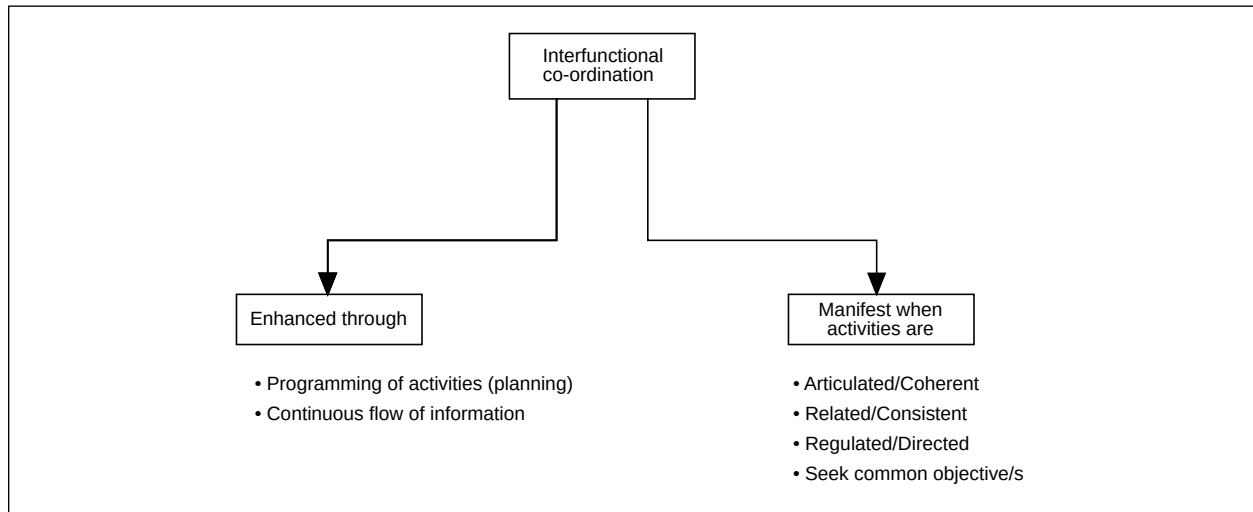
While task specialization results in differentiated and individualized roles within an organization, such roles are typically neither unrelated nor independent of one another. To the contrary, they tend to be mutually complementary and supplementary, particularly if they reflect a common goal. From the perspective of product managers, this interdependence of differentiated and specialized departments (e.g. R&D, production, finance, accounting and sales) establishes a justification for their work. Indeed, the need for coordination and integration of the specialized tasks related to the development, production and marketing of products is both essential to, and inevitable in, successful multi-product organizations

(Ruekert and Walker, 1987b). This need is perhaps more acute today than ever before, given the smarter, tougher, more demanding market, which includes both customers and retailers who want quick and high quality responses to their often changing needs and desires (Power, 1992).

In this article, the meaning of coordination is the extent to which the work activities of organizational members (functional departments) are logically consistent and coherent with respect to achieving pre-established performance objectives (where all members of the team are in synch with one other). This definition characterizes coordination as a measurable organizational state and is compatible with the conceptualizations of Georgopoulos and Mann (1962), Lawrence and Lorsch (1967) and Cheng (1983). Referring again to Figure 1, our focus here is on the degree to which product managers' information power enables them to enhance interfunctional coordination among the various departments assigned to develop, produce and market a given product or brand. More specifically, the influence of a product manager's information power on "fine tuning" the organization's interfunctional coordination (over and above that achieved by pre-established policies, authorities, or other formal mechanisms) is of interest.

As depicted in Figure 4, and suggested by March and Simon (1958), Thompson (1967) and Hage (1980), boundary spanners can enhance interfunctional coordination in two basic ways. First, by programming the activities of the various departments involved, and, second, by providing a continuous flow of information, and timely feedback in and between departments such that interfunctional co-ordination is harmonized with changing market demands. In theory and practice, successful product managers, utilizing meaningful information gleaned from internal and external environments, tend to have enormous influence on departmental plans and





**Figure 4.**  
**Enhancement and Manifestations of Interfunctional Coordination**

activities. In all cases, enhancement of interfunctional coordination occurs only when information is well articulated and coherent, related and consistent, and directed toward common goals. Without these attributes, no amount of boundary spanning (inside or outside) will give a product manager the information power needed to achieve a high degree of interfunctional coordination.

Based on this logic, it can be concluded that skilled product managers (particularly those who are focussed on the market and emphasize outside boundary spanning) may use their information power to fine tune the activities of other functional departments and thus enhance interfunctional coordination. As such, the following proposition is advanced:

*P3: The greater the information power of product managers, the higher the interfunctional coordination of relevant functional departments.*

### Job Related Outcomes

Lyonski (1985) and Lyonski and Woodside (1989) note that the product management system has a tendency to produce high turnover among product managers, which

lowers overall organizational performance. Some observers think that this may be one of the greatest problems with product management because “few product managers stay on a brand long enough to really learn what makes it work” (Dewar and Schultz, 1989). There may be a solution, however, as it has also been found that the high turnover-low performance relationship can be moderated by job satisfaction, at least in the context of salespeople (Futrell and Parasuraman, 1984). Because of this, and the theoretically appealing relationship between the performance and job satisfaction of product managers, performance and job satisfaction are posited as major outcome variables in the model depicted in Figure 1.

### Performance of Product Managers

Performance of product managers can be measured in a number of ways (e.g. profitability, market share, sales volume), depending on the overall goals of their organizations. As emphasized previously, in order to achieve their goals, product managers must coordinate the activities of a variety of functional departments such that their differentiated activities are consistent and

coherent. While no previous study has explored this relationship in the product management context, a number of studies have reported positive relationships between coordination and organizational performance in other contexts (Birnbaum, 1981; Cheng, 1983; Georgopoulos and Mann, 1962; Lawrence and Lorsch, 1967). As such, the following proposition is advanced:

*P4:* The higher the level of interfunctional coordination among relevant functional departments, the greater the performance of product managers.

### **Job Satisfaction of Product Managers**

Job satisfaction has been studied extensively in a variety of settings including sales management and marketing, and has been related to numerous facets of one's work, including compensation, promotional opportunities and job security (Bagozzi, 1978). It is manifest as an occupational consequence, and is considered to be highly salient in many contexts (Szilagyi and Wallace, 1980). Several studies in sales management have associated personal job satisfaction with absenteeism, turnover and commitment (Apasu, 1986; Futrell and Parasuraman, 1984; Michaels *et al.*, 1988; Parasuraman and Futrell, 1983). Likewise, empirical work presented by Bagozzi (1978, 1980) in a selling context provided evidence that job performance is positively related to job satisfaction. In other words, performance may be a source of satisfaction. Based on these results, the following proposition is advanced:

*P5:* The higher the level of product managers' performance, the higher their personal job satisfaction.

One other source of job satisfaction is posited in the model (Figure 1), namely information power. This relationship is based on a long line of research beginning with Shaffer (1953), who argued that individuals derive job

satisfaction from the fulfillment of other needs; "overall job satisfaction will vary directly with the extent to which those needs of the individual which can be satisfied in a job are actually satisfied" (p. 108). Others (Oliver and DeSarbo, 1988) later added that individuals can have multiple motives which they seek to fulfill in a job, including the need for achievement, the need for affiliation and the need for power. In theory, product managers' need for power can be fulfilled through their ability to attain information power, which in turn could impact on overall job satisfaction. Based on this reasoning, the following proposition is advanced:

*P6:* The higher the level of product managers' information power, the higher their personal job satisfaction.

### **Moderators to the Core Theory**

The previous discussion and the six propositions advanced constitute the core theory of the model presented in Figure 1. In general, this conceptualization posits causal relationships between product managers' boundary spanning activities (particularly outside boundary spanning activities), information power, interfunctional coordination, and job related outcomes (performance and job satisfaction). However, other behavioral factors and organizational characteristics may significantly affect the core relationships represented in this model. In particular, as depicted in Figure 1, the behavioral consequences labeled "role conflict" and "role ambiguity," and the organizational characteristic labeled "strategic orientation", merit consideration.

### **Behavioral Consequences: Role Conflict and Role Ambiguity**

The theory of role dynamics, developed by Kahn *et al.* (1964) and later substantiated by

Keller *et al.* (1976), supports the contention that boundary spanners may be “caught in the middle” of conflicting goals and/or ambiguous situations. Prior empirical research in marketing has also demonstrated that role conflict and role ambiguity can adversely influence job-related outcomes (Bagozzi, 1978; Behrman and Perreault, 1984; Lysonski, 1985; Lysonski and Woodside, 1989). Role conflict is defined as “the degree of incongruity or incompatibility of expectations associated with the role”, and role ambiguity is defined as “the degree to which a person is uncertain about others’ expectations with respect to the job, the best ways to fulfill known role expectations, and the consequences of different aspects of role performance” (Miles and Perreault, 1976, p. 22). Both role conflict and role ambiguity can be manifest in the context of a product manager’s job as a boundary spanner, where diverse interactions may result in different expectations which, at times, may be conflicting and unclear.

This may be particularly apparent in today’s market. During the 1980s, as natural market growth slowed, many consumer goods companies satisfied the financial community’s demand for sustained growth through mergers and acquisitions, which led to increased costs in the form of high debt ratios. In an attempt to maintain earnings levels (and dividend demands), a shift in orientation has occurred. Volume-at-any-cost has been replaced by return-on-investment (a bottom-line orientation). In this environment, traditional product management approaches to growth, such as new product development, packaging innovation and free product samplers, all of which have a direct impact on costs and thus profits, have become less appropriate (Saporito, 1992). This, in conjunction with the fact that consumers are now less receptive to mass advertising (another traditional approach of product management), has many product managers confused and bewildered. Likewise,

the rise of retail power with corresponding demands, including extra payments for a product’s inclusion in retailer controlled local advertisements, “slotting allowance” payments for a product’s placement on a retailer’s shelf, and increasing demands for large numbers of free samples, have some product managers thinking they now work in an environment that is unethical, if not illegal (Schiller, 1992). The potential for role conflict and role ambiguity in such situations may be significant.

Role conflict and role ambiguity are considered to be behavioral consequences of boundary spanning activities. They are directly related to the intensity and demands of such activities as determined by the turbulence of the environment in which boundary spanning is undertaken. In regard to product managers, the more demanding they find their boundary spanning activities (i.e. the greater the degree to which they face a new and unknown environment where traditional approaches and concepts are less valid), the greater is the possibility that they will be faced with a role that is both ambiguous and in conflict. Grounded in this train of thought, and as depicted in Figure 1, the following propositions are advanced:

*P7:* The more demanding product managers’ boundary spanning activities (i.e. the greater the degree to which they face an unknown, exacting and perhaps unethical environment), the higher their role conflict.

*P8:* The more demanding product managers’ boundary spanning activities (i.e. the greater the degree to which they face an unknown, exacting and perhaps unethical environment), the higher their role ambiguity.

As also shown in Figure 1, role conflict and role ambiguity can have both a direct and indirect effect on job-related outcomes. In

regard to direct effects, a significant amount of research by organizational and marketing theorists tends to confirm that role conflict can lead to both lower job performance and satisfaction (House and Rizzo, 1972; Kahn *et al.*, 1964; Lysonski and Woodside, 1989; Miles 1976). As such, the following propositions are advanced:

*P9:* The higher product managers' role conflict, the lower their job performance.

*P10:* The higher product managers' role conflict, the lower their job satisfaction.

*P11:* The higher product managers' role ambiguity, the lower their job performance.

*P12:* The higher product managers' role ambiguity, the lower their job satisfaction.

Role conflict and role ambiguity are also posited to have an indirect effect on performance and satisfaction through information power. While there is no theoretical or empirical work to suggest this relationship, anecdotal evidence abounds (Power, 1992; Urbanski, 1987). Again, the core theory of the model focusses on a product manager's ability to acquire information power and enhance interfunctional coordination as manifest when departmental activities are coherent, related and directed toward common goals. In some cases, a manager who finds him or herself in a conflicting and ambiguous environment may have significant problems knowing which pieces of information are meaningful or how to access them. In such cases, the core relationships necessary for enhanced performance and satisfaction may never come about. Based on this reasoning, the following propositions are advanced:

*P13:* The higher product managers' role conflict, the lower their information power (and, ultimately, the lower their job performance and job satisfaction).

*P14:* The higher product managers' role ambiguity, the lower their information power (and, ultimately, the lower their job performance and job satisfaction).

### ***Strategic Orientation: A Moderating Organizational Characteristic***

We now turn to the last construct in the model. According to the theory presented, as environmental turbulence and instability increase, boundary spanning activities of product managers become more critical to an organization's ability to adapt, survive and prosper. Likewise, as uncertainty increases, those who have meaningful information and the skill to manage conflict and tolerate ambiguity gain power and ultimately success. However, the notion that "flexible" individuals in critical information positions are the sole means by which organizations can deal with environmental uncertainty has been challenged by a variety of scholars proposing a "strategic contingency" school of thought (Aldrich, 1979; Bourgeois, 1980; Porter, 1979; Zeithaml and Zeithaml, 1984). They posit that the environmental uncertainties faced by any given organization depend in part on its strategic orientation and, as such, an organization can, to some degree, select and determine the environment that it will face.

A second premise of this school of thought is that the strategic orientation adopted by an organization may determine the power patterns manifest in the organization. This is particularly relevant to the present study because it is our contention that, in a product management context, the strategic orientation adopted by the product management group (see Figure 2) may moderate product managers' ability to acquire information power within their organizations.

The strategic management and organization behavior literature offers several frameworks concerning alternative strategic orientations

that can be adopted by organizations (Anderson and Piane, 1975; Etzioni, 1961; Segal, 1974). However, most of these frameworks are normative, highly situational, and not appropriate for research where the aim is generalizability across industries or settings (Hofer and Schendel, 1978). The typology offered by Miles and Snow (1978), however, is based on empirical research conducted in several industries. Their typology views the organization as a complete and integrated system in dynamic interaction with its environment. Briefly, Miles and Snow postulate that competing organizations within an industry may exhibit one of four basic strategic orientations, namely: defenders, prospectors, analyzers, or reactors. A key dimension differentiating these is the rate at which the organization changes its products and markets. In theory, each orientation may influence the choice of environments faced by an organization.

#### *Defenders*

“Defender” type organizations deliberately choose a narrow and stable product/market domain and concentrate on serving current and traditional customers by achieving extreme technological efficiency. This choice of a narrow domain is said to create organizational stability by reducing the organization’s reactivity to external change and uncertainty. While defenders will take an aggressive stance to “defend” their position, they have a tendency to ignore developments outside their immediate domain. Therefore, extensive environmental scanning is not common and defenders tend to allocate only a minimum amount of administrative time and personnel to monitor other organizations, events or trends not considered crucial to their organizational performance. Their focus is on immediately relevant boundary spanning activities, which results in a relatively low need to cope with and absorb uncertainty.

Miles and Snow speculate that, within organizations adopting the defender orientation, boundary spanners, in general, will not be very influential in dominant coalitions (such as product groups). Hence, in theory, product managers may not have an opportunity to attain significant information power within defender type organizations.

#### *Prospectors*

“Prospector” type organizations reside at the other extreme of the continuum, as they continuously search for, and attempt to exploit, new product and market opportunities. As such, they tend to be creators of change in their industry, and their products and markets are in a much greater state of fluidity. To survive and prosper, prospectors develop and maintain an extensive capacity to monitor a wide range of environmental conditions, events and trends. Likewise, they greatly value those who can absorb uncertainty. Miles and Snow speculate that boundary spanners within prospector organizations will gain significant positions of power as they have access to and control over valuable information.

#### *Analyzers*

While defenders and prospectors reside at opposite end of the strategic orientation continuum, “analyzers” occupy a position in between these two extremes, and represent a viable alternative to each. A true analyzer organization minimizes risk while maximizing opportunity for profit. It carefully balances its risks and returns by adopting new products or new markets only after their viability has been demonstrated. In general, analyzers tend to imitate only the most successful products or market innovations developed by prominent prospectors. In turn, these traits tend to increase the value and, thus, the dependency they place on market and other information.

As stated by Miles and Snow, “Successful imitation [by analyzers] is accomplished through extensive marketing surveillance systems” (1978, p. 72). As such, boundary spanning activities become critical to the performance of analyzer organizations. In theory, product managers (through their ability to generate and disseminate information) should enhance their information power and become highly influential in such organizations.

### *Reactors*

The fourth and final strategic orientation, “reactors”, is characterized as lacking a consistent strategy. Reactors simply respond to environmental pressures when forced to do so. Their behavior is typically depicted as very ambiguous, with no set pattern or logic behind the number and kinds of markets they enter or products they offer. As such, the influence of boundary spanners in reactor organizations could vary significantly. Product managers in such organizations may or may not have information power.

Based on the discussion presented, it can be posited that the relationship between product managers’ boundary spanning activities and their information power may be moderated by the strategic orientation of their organization or, more specifically, the orientation adopted by their product management group. In theory, the product manager who operates under a prospector or an analyzer orientation will experience enhanced information power relative to the product manager operating under a defender orientation. Under a reactor orientation, no consistent pattern will be apparent. In this regard, again as shown in Figure 1, the following propositions are advanced:

*P15:* The greater the number of meaningful boundary spanning activities performed by product managers, the greater their

information power *when* their organization adopts a prospector or analyzer orientation.

*P16:* No matter what the level of meaningful boundary spanning activities performed by product managers, their information power is lower *when* their organization adopts a defender orientation.

*P17:* The relationship between product managers’ meaningful boundary spanning activities and their information power is inconsistent *when* their organization adopts a reactor orientation.

## **Discussion and Managerial Implications**

We again acknowledge that effective product management may be determined by a myriad of variables (personal, organizational and environmental) not posited in this article. There is probably no single equation that can fully and completely explain product managers’ success and satisfaction. However, we again ask: What are the *key* ingredients to successful product management? In an effort to provide a theory-based answer to this question, we have developed a conceptual model (Figure 1) which relates product managers’ boundary spanning activities, the consequences of such activities (information power, role conflict and role ambiguity), and organizational characteristics (interfunctional coordination and strategic orientation), to job-related outcomes (product managers’ job performance and job satisfaction).

Even in less turbulent times, product managers asked: How can we continually nurture our brands so as to avoid their “commoditization” and easy substitutability? How can we insure that our customers will continue to ask for our products? And, how do we give our brands a reputation for quality and value that transcends a competitor’s lower price or discounted offerings? Answers to these and similar questions have consistently resulted in long-term product management

success and personal satisfaction. Today, such questions are still asked and their answers are still sought for the same reasons.

In today's more turbulent times, however, product managers are faced by a changing environment that requires them to be fully cognizant of the forces which surround them. These forces include the growth of retail power due to rapid advance in the development and use of compelling technologies, the continued deterioration of the effectiveness of traditional product management techniques (including mass advertisings, one time price discounts, common packaging and standardized product features), and the rise in the number of new consumers who are more sophisticated, more knowledgeable and more demanding. The model offered in this article provides additional insight into the challenges facing product managers and it begins with a rethinking, and reprioritizing of traditional boundary spanning activities.

Product managers of the 1990s and beyond will need to rethink whom they are targeting as a market, and how they should coordinate and integrate the many people involved with successful product management. On the marketing side, outside boundary activities should take priority and should focus on both retailer and consumer needs. Product managers' interaction with retailers should aim at answering questions such as the following:

- Should we concentrate on smaller niche retailers, or large power retailers, or both?
- Should a special delivery schedule be offered to certain retailers?
- Do we need one individual or a team of individuals to service our retailers' promotional, financial, logistics and merchandising needs?
- Can we redesign our packaging to enhance retail return on shelf space?

- To what degree and how should we seek retailer input with respect to new product development and product alterations?
- How can we (brand managers), in conjunction with retailers, demonstrate a keen interest in targeting customers and developing a "brand and store" building strategy?

On the consumer side, product managers must focus on answering questions such as the following:

- What do our customers like and dislike about our offerings, our retailers, our promotion and our pricing efforts?
- What do they like and dislike about our competition?
- How is our market changing and how can we position ourselves to take advantage of such changes?

It is important for product managers to remember that retail- and consumer-focussed outside boundary spanning activities are not mutually exclusive. A product manager's best hope of sustaining or recapturing a meaningful measure of relevance among consumers rests, to a great extent, on establishing a marketing-based link with retailers, often called "co-marketing" or "relationship marketing" in today's jargon (Hoyt, 1993; Sellers, 1991). In such linkages, an on-going dialog and partnership between a product manager and retailer replaces the more traditional one-shot "transactional" orientation of the past. In the new age, product managers' outside boundary spanning activities can no longer focus on the cleverness of their advertising message, or on the outdated results of antiquated market research information (e.g. arbitron ratings), but must focus on the kinds of individual relationships that need to be formed with retailers, current customers, and prospective customers.

It is from this perspective that information power is acquired, and interfunctional

coordination (see Figure 1) is enhanced. From meaningful outside boundary spanning activities involving retailers, consumers, and other relevant constituencies (see Figure 2), comes the means by which product managers can coordinate and integrate the many functional areas within their organizations. To possess information power, brand managers must convince their organizational counterparts that they understand who their customers are, why they are buying specific brands, why they keep coming back, and how they are changing. From here derives the wherewithal to refine and improve interfunctional coordination. It is here that the organizational team members responsible for the many activities necessary for brand success come to have a common vision of what their products are all about, and what their message in regard to filling consumer needs must be. It is here that strategies for success are developed, implemented and evaluated, including creating promotions that highlight a brand's advantages, establishing distribution systems that maximize consumer time and location preferences, and formulating products and packages that strengthen relationships with retailers.

When the system is fully understood and fully in place, product manager success and satisfaction are posited to be enhanced. For all of retailing's advances from information technologies, retailers are still, for the most part, novices at marketing. While many retailers would like to believe they know more about consumers than do product managers, their claim is limited because they tend to track only the purchasing patterns of the shoppers who come into their stores. They lack information about the demographics, psychographics, and purchasing patterns of shoppers who never patronize their outlets. The consumers that retailers do not have are precisely the ones they need, and the ones that product managers can help identify, motivate and win over. Product managers in the 1990s

must learn to leverage their expertise (gained through meaningful boundary spanning activities) to advocate their vision of the key ingredients of product management success.

Finally, upper management, and/or product managers' supervisors, must be aware of the part it plays in the success (or failure) of modern product management. As articulated in this article, it must understand the nature and impact of role ambiguity and role conflict in product managers' jobs, and must then strive to keep these behavioral consequences within functional limits. Upper management must explicitly state what its product managers are to be accomplishing, and when they are to be accomplishing it. It must also set the overall direction and culture of the organization by deciding what the orientation of its operations will be. Will it be proactive or reactive (as defined by the organizational types discussed in this paper – defender, prospector, analyzer, and reactor)? Indeed, without sound guidance from superiors, no product management system can guarantee success.

## Conclusions

No matter what new positions the product management system may come to be built around (e.g. category manager, geographic manager, key accounts manager), a single individual or "product manager" will (must) be assigned the ultimate responsibility for assuring high market performance for both new and current products (Loden, 1992). The challenge lies in successfully executing that responsibility in today's turbulent consumer goods environment. Product management success will continue to require consistent and coherent contributions from other departments inside the organization, including research and development, production, finance, accounting and sales. However, it will also require a significant reorientation toward the outside



environment, particularly toward customers and retailers. Skilled outside boundary spanners who nurture and care for brands in the field, while supplying the information necessary to achieve a high degree of co-ordination within the organization, are needed. Who will possess these skills? Some observers believe that a hybrid “sales-product manager”, one that speaks the language of the street and the company, may well be the key to future product management success (Dewar and Schultz, 1989).

More specifically, the theory presented here implies a number of unambiguous recommendations for product managers seeking success and satisfaction in the 1990s and beyond. According to the theory presented, the job performance and job satisfaction of future product managers depends on a plethora of behavioral and organizational factors, all working in harmony. While theoretically compelling, empirical verification of the proposed linkages in the model is required. Future research should focus on a number of key questions, including: Do product managers gain information power through boundary spanning activities? If so, is such power driven primarily by inside or outside boundary spanning, or is a unique combination of the two more important? Does information power facilitate interfunctional coordination and, ultimately, high job performance and job satisfaction? Do strategic orientations moderate the relationship between boundary spanning activities and information power? And if so, how? What effect do the behavioral consequences of boundary spanning, namely role conflict and role ambiguity, have on product managers’ ability to garner information power, achieve interfunctional co-ordination and, ultimately, realize job high performance and job satisfaction?

The answers to these questions should lead to a richer understanding of the forces that are challenging today’s product managers.

Ultimately, such understanding will have direct implications for the design, practice and evaluation of product managers’ positions, including the allocation of product managers’ time by activity, the selection criteria of individuals to be product managers, and the overall strategic orientation of their organizations.

□

## Note

1. A note of clarification is appropriate here. While closely related, information power should not be confused with expert power. Raven (1965, 1974) and Raven and Kruglanski (1970) state that the two are quite distinct and involve different dynamics. If a target or receiver of information complies with the wishes of the source or provider of information because the target has faith in the source’s expertise (and hence his or her recommendations), expert power is the basis of influence exerted. In contrast, if the target is influenced by the content of the information provided by the source, information power is the basis of influence exerted. While expert power is based on formal and/or specialized knowledge about some particular issue within the organization, it is distinguishable from information power, which is obtained by being located at a certain position in an organization that gives one access to and control over information which is valued by others (Benfari *et al.*, 1986). Information power is theorized in this article to be a key basis of power for product managers because of the very nature of the product management job. That is, by being responsible for coordinating multiple tasks, involving multiple parties (e.g. production, R&D, sales), product managers would be expected to be generalists (rather than experts) in many areas. Therefore, information power, more so than expert power, would pervade their domain.

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- Van R. Wood is Professor of Marketing at Texas Technical University, Lubbock, Texas, and Sudhir Tandon is Assistant Professor of Marketing at Texas A&M University, Prairie View, Houston, Texas.